

Lesson 1: Knowing Your Priorities

Joan Cronan

You know, in life, it's important that you know your priorities and you live your priorities. If Pat Summitt was standing here right now, she would tell you her priorities were academics and then athletics. She looked at the basketball court as her classroom.

If you ask her what she was proudest of, she would say, I'm proudest of the academic success that every young lady who played for me for four years graduated. She wouldn't say, I won eight national championships, I went to 18 final fours. Folks, people dream of going to one final four. Pat Summitt went to 18 final fours. Pat Summitt believed in academics.

One of my favorite stories on Pat is when she was recruiting a young lady from Kentucky. This young lady was a great athlete, but she came from a very poor part of the world and a very poor academic background. And she mentioned to me that she was worried about this young lady being able to succeed at Tennessee. Well, in our world, you can go in and visit in their home, then you can visit, bring them in and visit on campus.

She went to visit her and she said, Joan, she really wants to come. Of course, as an AD, I said, how good is she? And she said, she's really good. So we brought her in to visit on campus. I'll never forget that Saturday. It was a Saturday that we had 107,000 people running around in Orange. It was a football Saturday. But I went to my office to meet with this young lady. And standing there was a tall, attractive, blonde young lady dressed in one of the most expensive looking suits that I'd ever seen. You can imagine my mind talk as I visited with her. I was picturing poverty and here was this model sitting in front of me. So finally, I said, you know, that's one of the prettiest suits I've ever seen.

She gave me the biggest smile. And she said, Ms. Cronin, when Pat came in to visit me, my mother drew a picture of the suit that Pat had on. And my mother made this suit for me to come visit.

Well, she came and she was successful. I was so excited. And her junior year, she was struggling. She was struggling academically. It wasn't that she wasn't trying. It wasn't that she wasn't capable. It was kind of like that treadmill you get on. You couldn't catch up. Because I called a summit conference.

I called Pat in, I called her academic advisor, and I called the young lady. And we talked about what it would take to be successful. And as a team, we decided that we would pull her out of practice and pull her off the road for three weeks where she would have time to catch up.

But we'd let her start at every home game. It's that lollipop we gave her to talk about success. The academic advisor came back. She said, Joan, she's doing great. So I said, okay. And she started competing and she started traveling.

We went down to the SEC tournament, and she made All-Tournament. We lost in the finals, but she had made all tournament. I was so glad we hadn't denied her an opportunity to be the best she could be.

Fast forward to her senior year, we're playing in the championship game. I'm trying to be sure everybody's got their tickets, the alumni are having the reception, the president's plane have landed, the coaches have what they need, and my phone rings at the hotel. And I answer it, and it's this young lady, and she's crying.

And I said, what's wrong? She said, I wanted you to be the first one to know that UT just called, and I made the Dean's List. So she made the Dean's List. She went on to help us win a national championship, and she became the first person in her family ever to graduate from college.

That's what I call success. So remember, we are teaching young people to be successful, just like you are teaching your employees to be successful and grow.